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What did California lawmakers talk about this year? These 10 bills sparked hours of debate

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Most bills in the California Legislature are barely talked about in public before lawmakers take action, often after secret negotiations with lobbyists.

But a handful of controversial proposals broke through the usual rushed process, drawing hours of testimony and intense public lobbying from some of the state's most powerful organizations that spend millions of dollars to get their way, according to an analysis of CalMatters' Digital Democracy database, which tracks every word spoken in the Legislature.

That's compared to the overall 2025 average, which showed lawmakers and advocates spent just 32 minutes publicly talking about each of the 1,657 bills that were discussed in at least one hearing.

These were the 10 most debated bills of the 2025 regular legislative session, according to Digital Democracy.

(Note: Advocacy groups listed below may have changed their positions as the bills were amended.)

Divide over antisemitism bill

Bill: Assembly Bill 715

Lead author: Democratic assemblymembers Dawn Addis of San Luis Obispo and Rick Zbur of Los Angeles.

Time discussed: 15 hours

Approximate number of speakers: 486

Why it was a talker: California's Jewish lawmakers made countering antisemitism in schools their top priority this year, but opposing the bill was a coalition of education groups, unions, civil rights advocates and Muslim community organizations who feared censorship of pro-Palestinian voices and infringement on academic freedom. The groups turned out in droves to testify.

Number of groups in support: At least 68, including the Jewish Community Action, the Los Angeles County Business Federation and the Simon Wiesenthal Center.

Number of groups opposed: At least 92, including the California Federation of Teachers, the California Chapter of the Council on American-Islamic Relations and the California School Boards Association.

Status: Signed into law.

Local governments balk at transit-oriented housing

Bill: Senate Bill 79

Lead author: Democratic Sen. Scott Wiener of San Francisco

Time discussed: 6 hours, 40 minutes

Approximate number of speakers: 198

Why it was a talker: Local governments balked at a new state mandate allowing developers to build midrise apartment buildings within walking distance of many major train, light-rail, subway and high-frequency rapid bus stations — even if local zoning restrictions would otherwise ban such dense development.

Number of groups in support: At least 49, including pro home-building groups and the California Apartment Association.

Number of groups opposed: At least 76, including, at one point, the building trades unions, the California Association of Realtors and dozens of municipalities.

Status: Signed into law.

Charter schools oppose new restrictions

Bill: Assembly Bill 84

Lead authors: Democratic assemblymembers Robert Garcia of Rancho Cucamonga and Al Muratsuchi of Torrance.

Time discussed: 6 hours, 32 minutes

Approximate number of speakers: 491

Why it was a talker: This was the latest legislative effort by California's powerful teachers unions and their allies to add restrictions and oversight to charter schools. Homeschool families and charter schools opposed the measure, introduced in response to high-profile charter school fraud scandals, saying it would strip millions of dollars in state funding from their programs. The bill added auditing requirements and new fees as well as a proposed new Office of Inspector General inside the Department of Education.

Number of groups in support: At least six, almost all influential unions.

Number of groups opposed: More than 200, many of them charter schools or home school groups.

Status: Failed in the Senate.

Uproar over teen sexual solicitation

Bill: Assembly Bill 379

Lead author: Democratic Assemblymember Stephanie Nguyen of Elk Grove

Time discussed: 5 hours, 28 minutes

Approximate number of speakers: 149

Why it was a talker: This bill, originally written by Democratic Assemblywoman Maggy Krell, a former state prosecutor, sought to increase penalties for soliciting teen sex. But the legislation sparked difficult discussions between progressive and moderate members of the Democratic caucus about how hard to crack down on those accused of soliciting sex from minors, based on whether the victims were younger or older teenagers.

Number of groups in support: At least 48, including law enforcement unions and some Native American tribes.

Number of groups opposed: At least 25, including ACLU and various advocates for progressive criminal justice reforms.

Status: Signed into law.

Lots to say about ICE agent masks

Bill: Senate Bill 627

Lead authors: Democratic Sen. Jessie Arreguín of Berkeley and three other senators

Time discussed: 5 hours

Approximate number of speakers: 100

Why it was a talker: Members of California's Democratic legislative supermajority aren't shy about speaking their minds on President Donald Trump and his controversial immigration policies, so it's no surprise that there was a lot of discussion over California's first-in-the nation measure to prohibit federal immigration officers and local police from wearing masks in California.

Number of groups in support: At least 45, including non-police unions, public defenders, the ACLU and immigrant rights groups.

Number of groups opposed: At least 16, almost all of them police unions.

Status: Signed into law

Democrats pitch gerrymander to counter Texas

Bill: Assembly Bill 604

Lead author: Democratic Assemblymember Cecilia Aguiar-Curry of Davis and Sen. Lena Gonzalez of Long Beach

Time discussed: 4 hours, 58 minutes

Approximate number of speakers: 76

Why it was a talker: There were plenty of heated discussions after California Democrats put forward their own gerrymandering plan after Trump pressured Texas to change its congressional maps to make new Republican districts.

Number of groups in support: At least 54, including labor unions and progressive groups.

Number of groups opposed: At least 19, including California Common Cause, Govern for California and conservative groups.

Status: Signed into law, approved by voters

Energy bill gets lengthy debate

Bill: Senate Bill 254

Lead authors: Democratic Sen. Josh Becker of Menlo Park and two other lawmakers

Time discussed: 4 hours, 55 minutes

Approximate number of speakers: 119

Why it was a talker: This energy bill created a new public financing system for electric transmission projects and extended a controversial program that shields utilities from some wildfire liability costs, but critics warned it could ultimately drive consumer bills higher. It was part of a package of energy and climate measures the Legislature passed this year.

Number of groups in support: At least 55, including trades unions, the California Democratic Party, the California Chamber of Commerce, environmental groups and the California Municipal Utilities Association.

Number of groups opposed: At least seven, including the California Farm Bureau Federation, Rural County Representatives of California and the California State Association of Counties.

Status: Signed into law.

Fees for veterans' benefits draws testimony

Bill: Senate Bill 694

Lead author: Democratic Sens. Bob Archuleta of Norwalk and Sabrina Cervantes of Riverside

Time discussed: 4 hours, 39 minutes

Approximate number of speakers: 99

Why it was a talker: For years, veterans advocates have wanted a state law preventing companies from charging exorbitant fees to help veterans file federal disability benefits claims, something they can do for free through the government and certain veterans' organizations. But the Legislature has repeatedly balked, as companies claim they provide an important service to help veterans get the benefits they need.

Number of groups in support: At least 25, including the California State Association of Counties and the American Legion.

Number of groups opposed: At least nine, including Veterans Guardian, one of the companies that files claims.

Status: The bill did not pass the Senate, although lawmakers announced they had a deal on the legislation and would vote on it in January.

Should AT&T opt out of landlines?

Bill: Assembly Bill 470

Lead author: Democratic Assemblymember Tina McKinnor of Inglewood

Time discussed: 4 hours, 13 minutes

Approximate number of speakers: 209

Why it was a talker: AT&T has spent millions in lobbying as it tried unsuccessfully to bow out of its legal requirement to provide copper landlines in much of the state. Rural communities and others pushed back, leading to some of the lengthiest discussions in the Legislature this year.

Number of groups in support: At least 145, including AT&T, some tribes and other groups aligned with the telecommunications company.

Number of groups opposed: At least 96, including rural counties, some unions and AARP.

Status: Failed in the Senate

Banning junk food at schools causes a stir

Bill: Assembly Bill 1264

Lead author: Democratic Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel of Encino

Time discussed: 3 hours, 49 minutes

Approximate number of speakers: 103

Why it was a talker: There were lots of strong opinions over this bill to ban schools from serving harmful "ultraprocessed foods" to students.

Number of groups in support: At least 59, including nurses and school unions, the California Medical Association and some school districts.

Number of groups opposed: At least 46, including agricultural associations, the American Beverage Association and other business trade groups.

Status: Signed into law.

Digital Democracy's Foaad Khosmood, Forbes professor of computer engineering at Cal Poly San Luis Obispo, and Digital Democracy's Thomas Gerrity contributed to this story.

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